640, Sweden 695, Switzerland 632, the UK 714, Ireland 526, Greece 433, Portugal 606 and Spain 661. Unfortunately, the author presented only one, uniform figure for the entire Eastern Europe – 496 dollars. Although we can probably assume that, in the year 1500, the GDP of Central European countries was higher than in the Ottoman-occupied areas or in the sparsely populated areas of Eastern Europe 'proper', the gap between the East and West was beginning to show. On the other hand, we can also see that the economy was poor in other fringe lands as well, such as modern-day Ireland, Finland and Greece.

The Czechs, the Hungarians and the Poles (less so the 'unhistorical' nations such as the Slovenes) developed impressive enough political structures in the Middle Ages, comparable with what existed in the west. For example, the medieval Bohemian (Czech) kings were among the key political players in Europe of the time. (Think of the magnificent Karlštejn castle of Emperor Charles IV.) Later the reformation movement of the Czech Jan Hus preceded that of Luther, and the Czechs were at the centre of the all-European political and religious dispute that caused the so-called Thirty Years' War, after which they were finally subdued by the Habsburgs. All in all, although political, social and economic development in parts of Eastern Europe in the Middle Ages began lagging behind that of mainstream Western Europe after the year 1000, there was little then to suggest a general backwardness of the region – and nothing that suggested a distinct name was required for this part of Europe.

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3. David Potter in *The Roman Empire at Bay* gives the battle at Frigidus, as it is usually referred to, a significance parallel to that of the battle at Adrianopolis. However, it seems symptomatic that Potter places the battle in northern Italy, whereas it actually took place in what is today Slovenia. Could it be that one has some difficulty in placing an important historical event in Eastern Europe? (Routledge, 2004, pp. 529–533).

4. Huntington, SP, *The Clash of Civilisations and the Remaking of the World Order,* The Free Press, 2002, pp. 157–161.

5. As quoted in Matzuzzi, M, *Il Santo Realismo: Il Vaticano come Potenza Politica Internazionale da Giovanni Paolo II a Francesco,* Luiss University Press 2021, p. 36.

6. 'In the prevailing narrative of European identity, "Europe" as an idea took shape only in the Middle Ages, when it succeeded the concept of Christendom. Both are Western: indeed, Christendom is often qualified as "Western Christendom". In this narrative of Europe, Byzantium is conspicuously absent. In historiography about the expanding (Western) Europe in the centuries after 1000, with its eastward adventures, Byzantium has usually featured as an ambivalence, less an ally than a duplicitous threat.' Quoted from Averil Cameron, *The Byzantines,* Blackwell, p. 165.